of 2023 was, in fact, a consequence of the law catching up with him. Umesh Pal was the key witness in the sensational streetside murder of his cousin-in-law and then Allahabad West MLA Raju Pal in 2005, one of the most high-profile ones attributed to Atiq's gang those days, and his kidnapping then had been a way to stop him from testifying. Back in the present, when Umesh Pal was gunned down dramatically in an alley near his house in Prayagraj on February 24, it was because he had at long last testified. This killing was said to have been the young Asad Ahmed's debut job and, as it turned out, his last one. Seven weeks on the run, with a Rs 5 lakh bounty on his head, ended in a hail of bullets in the Jhansi 'encounter' for Asad. What the CM had said in the aftermath of Pal's killing, alleging that SP had nurtured the mafioso—'*mitti mein mila denge*' (will ground them to dust)—had come to pass. Asad was killed on April 13, the same day Atiq was produced before a magistrate's court in Prayagraj in the Umesh Pal case. Everything suggested the wheel of law was turning inexorably, even if unmindful of niceties, when it unexpectedly jolted to a full circle two days later even for Atiq and his brother Ashraf.

When the Turkish-made Zigana pistol snaked through the scanty police cordon and got Atiq, he had barely begun his sentence. Both his life sentence, announced three weeks before, and the words he was mumbling into a TV crew's microphone about his inability to attend his son's funeral earlier that day. Three nowhere boys out of mofussil Uttar Pradesh had accomplished a hit job with ruthless professionalism—right down to what seemed like a pat surrender. What they let loose, from guns clearly way beyond their means, might as well have been a volley of question marks (see *The Life & Crimes of Atiq Ahmed*). Many experienced UP observers cite an unlikely string of enabling coincidences for the shooters to hint at vested interests who could have wanted Atiq neutralised. It is well known that Atiq had dealings across the party spectrum, apart from sections of the administration, and simply knew too much. He could have been a threat to them if he started squawking once he began serving his term in jail and had nothing to lose.

SETBACK AND AFTER

For Yogi, trying assiduously as he has been to embed his crackdown within a more solid legal framework, the potential impact of that dramatic murder is again made up of contradictory layers. At one level, it could only conceivably have been a setback. He had one of UP's big dons pinned to the wall—via the courts. Having a runaway Asad falling to police bullets on a dark street 30 km outside Jhansi was another thing. Yogi has continued to wager on the psychological impact 'encounter killings' grant—as a species that inhabits the hazy frontiers of justice, they send out a no-nonsense signal of deterrence while doing no harm to his street cred. But a live TV killing he could perhaps do without, especially in front of sloppy cops who could not—or did not—lift a finger in time. That too by a scrappy trio barely above the category of juvenile delinquents, shouting 'Jai Shri Ram' slogans after a murder. By association, it could colour his whole mafia crackdown in hues he was arguably trying to avoid.

A black swan event? Or a death foretold? After all, Atiq and Ashraf had red-flagged the danger to their lives to anyone who willing to listen, and even appealed in vain to the Supreme Court for a shift out of UP. There was also that classic trope of a fatal premonition: a sealed envelope to be despatched three ways, just in case. Indeed, even the media's feeding frenzy seemed to amp up the sense of anticipation... till it became part of the story. At any rate, after the CCTV footage of the Umesh Pal killing, this was the second time the trigger-happy ways of organised crime were being broadcast—not the best prescription for the 'law and order' narrative the chief minister had touted. The fact that Atiq was in police custody and the state force was clearly lax in doing its duty was not a badge of honour. A murder that could exacerbate feelings of insecurity among Muslims was also not the logical recipe when the BJP was attempting to pull off a seemingly incongruent feat—wooing the Muslims, especially the Pasmandas. So Yogi took extra care to ensure the event had no cascading effect: Section 144 was clamped on the whole state, and Prayagraj saw the internet suspended. The blowback had to be minimised on the streets.

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Next, the stain on the police had to be cleansed. To ensure that the investigation is not compromised in any way, it has been made a tripartite auditing process. One is a three-member judicial committee to probe the killing, headed by retired Allahabad High Court judge Arvind Kumar Tripathi, and including retired judge Brijesh Kumar Soni and former DGP Subesh Kumar Singh. Then, the UP Police formed two special investigating teams (SITs)—the first, headed by Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police (crime) Satish Chandra, will probe the murder itself; the second, headed by two top cops and a forensics lab director, will monitor the first. When Yogi mentioned the "rule of law" in his first indirect allusion to the Atiq case on April 19, it's this restoration of order that he likely meant—with good reason. Explains Professor A.P. Tiwari, former dean of academics at Shakuntala Misra University in Lucknow, "The narrative of law and order was one of the major reasons behind Yogi's 2022 victory...it may not have been so easy without it. It also played an important role in the kind